

IN TEST: 10 OCR PACKAGES

This is a test document specifically created for the OCR test. Here, in this test, we will try and figure out the accuracy of the OCR test. As far as accuracy goes, we will be trying to measure the number of correct words, or more specifically the number of errors that were reported by the software. Specific cases we will be measuring are words that contain continuous letters such as mississippi or millennium.



Read Right and Recognise...

that's what optical character recognition (OCR) software is all about. A look at the best of them

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Ever done research in your college days? How you must have wished there was a way to get an editable copy of all the research material that you'd painstakingly photocopied from the college library. Well, if you have a scanner, or even if you can get the pages scanned and save it as an image file, then an OCR software will do the job of converting it into text format that you can easily edit in your word processor.

Makes your life quite simple, doesn't it? The technology behind the OCR software—the OCR engine that ensures that you get accurate recognition—is quite a marvel, but let's forget the engine, and see how the software actually fare.

The OCR field

We tested 10 OCR packages in all, of which three—OmniPage Pro 10, TextBridge Pro Millennium and Recognita Plus 5.0—are from the same company, ScanSoft, though there's a separate Web site for the last product mentioned.

The other popular OCR software we tested included Fine Reader 5.0 (the latest version, as opposed to 4.0 that was available last year), and Presto! OCR. The remaining OCR tested included Expervision Typereader 6.0, ReadIris Pro 6.0 and PageGenei Pro. Wocar 2.5 is the only one among the lot that came for free. Most of the OCR software had a fully functional trial version available for download, and those are the ones we used for testing, except in the case of FineReader, OmniPage and TextBridge, where we received a box pack. The OCR software cover a range of features from allowing you to scan normal printed documents to fax and dot matrix printouts. But if you are looking for the software to recognise your handwriting, then you better forget it...that's still miles away.

Accurate to a dot

As we expected, the accuracy of the OCR software was highest with the laser document (with an average accuracy of 99.68 per cent). The